

Bitcoin For The Arts, Inc. — Executive Summary

Prepared for: Draper Richards Kaplan Foundation Application **Organization:** Bitcoin For The Arts, Inc. (BFTA) **Status:** 501(c)(3) Tax-Exempt Nonprofit **Founded:** 2025 | New York, NY
Website: bitcoinforthearts.org **Contact:** Dion Wilson, Founder & Executive Director — dionwilson@bitcoinforthearts.org

Problem and Solution

Mission and Objectives

Bitcoin For The Arts, Inc. (BFTA) exists to ignite a self-sustaining global renaissance in the arts by connecting independent creators with Bitcoin-native funding, financial literacy, and censorship-resistant distribution tools. Our mission is to pay artists directly in Bitcoin through micro-grants, performance workshops, residencies, and live/digital productions — empowering visual artists, playwrights, dancers, musicians, and filmmakers to build sovereign creative careers free from institutional gatekeepers.

Our objectives are:

1. Fund independent artists through Bitcoin micro-grants (\$500–\$25,000), starting with quarterly grant cycles in 2026.
2. Educate artists on financial sovereignty through workshops on Bitcoin self-custody, value-for-value models, and censorship-resistant publishing.
3. Build a permanent Bitcoin reserve (the "HODL Vault") that generates long-term, inflation-resistant funding for the arts — targeting 1 BTC by 2030 as a foundation for perpetual grant-making.
4. Create a replicable model for Bitcoin-native arts patronage that other communities and institutions can adopt.

The Social Problem

Independent artists face a compounding crisis of financial precarity, platform dependence, and institutional gatekeeping:

- **Financial precarity:** The median income for working artists in the U.S. is approximately \$35,000/year (NEA, 2022). Artists are disproportionately affected by inflation, as their income is irregular while costs for studio space, materials, travel, and production rise steadily. Traditional arts funding is concentrated among large institutions — the top 2% of arts nonprofits receive over 60% of all philanthropic arts funding.
- **Platform censorship:** Artists who create politically challenging, culturally provocative, or ideologically independent work face growing risks of deplatforming, shadow-banning, and algorithmic suppression. Musicians, visual artists, and writers have had work removed from Spotify, Instagram, YouTube, and other major platforms for content that challenges mainstream narratives — with no meaningful appeal process.
- **Fiat system fragility:** Traditional grant funding is denominated in depreciating currency, subject to institutional politics, and often restricted to narrow use cases. Artists in the Global South face additional barriers: currency instability, limited banking access, and predatory intermediaries that consume 10–30% of cross-border payments.
- **Lack of direct artist-to-audience connection:** The existing creator economy funnels artists through centralized platforms that extract 30–50% of revenue, control distribution, and own the relationship between creator and audience.

Our Solution

BFTA addresses these problems through four integrated programs, all settled on Bitcoin's open monetary network:

1. **Bitcoin Micro-Grants:** Direct grants of \$500–\$2,000 (scaling to \$25,000 as reserves grow), paid in BTC to artists' self-custody wallets. No intermediaries, no currency conversion fees for recipients who hold BTC. Grant cycles begin Q3 2026.
2. **Bitcoin For Artists Workshops:** Hands-on education in self-custody, receiving Bitcoin, value-for-value models, and using censorship-resistant platforms (Nostr, Wavlake, Fountain). Designed for artists with zero prior Bitcoin knowledge.
3. **Sovereign Artist Residency Program (proposed):** Funded residencies providing stipends of \$1,000–\$5,000 in BTC, studio access, and mentorship — enabling artists to create without financial pressure while learning sovereign tools.

4. **Community & Storytelling:** Our Artist Stories series and open-licensed "Share Your Bitcoin Journey" episodes document real creators building independent careers with Bitcoin, creating a public knowledge base for the broader arts community.

What makes our approach unique:

- **First nonprofit paying artists exclusively in Bitcoin.** Every grant is denominated and settled in BTC, aligning artistic sovereignty with monetary sovereignty.
- **Radical transparency.** Governance documents, board minutes, bylaws, allocation ratios, and program proposals are published openly on our website. We share aggregated financial reporting while protecting sensitive wallet addresses for security.
- **55/30/10/5 allocation model.** 55% of donations go directly to artist grants, 30% to programs, 10% to operations, and 5% to the HODL Vault — a Bitcoin endowment designed to appreciate in purchasing power over time, creating a perpetually growing funding base.
- **Censorship-resistant infrastructure.** Our tech stack is open-source (Next.js), payments are processed through BTCPay Server (self-hosted, non-custodial), and we actively onboard artists to Nostr and value-for-value platforms.

Impact

How BFTA Improves on Existing Efforts

Traditional arts funding operates within the fiat financial system: grants are denominated in depreciating dollars, processed through slow institutional channels, and often restricted to narrow project categories. BFTA introduces three structural improvements:

1. **Appreciating-currency grants.** By paying in Bitcoin, grants have the potential to increase in purchasing power over time — turning a \$1,000 grant into significantly more if the artist holds rather than immediately converts. This aligns incentives: artists are introduced to sound money principles through the grant itself.
2. **Permissionless, borderless delivery.** A Bitcoin grant can reach an artist in Tanzania, Australia, or New York in minutes, with no bank intermediaries, no currency conversion fees, and no risk of account freezing. This is especially critical for artists in countries with restricted banking (e.g., Australia's treatment of Bitcoin purchasers, as documented in our Matt Finlay artist story).

3. **Bundled financial literacy.** Every grant recipient goes through our workshop curriculum on self-custody and Bitcoin basics. We don't just fund art — we equip artists with tools for long-term financial independence.

Underserved Population

BFTA serves independent artists who are:

- **Economically precarious:** Working artists earning below the median, lacking access to institutional grants or gallery representation.
- **Ideologically independent:** Artists whose work challenges mainstream narratives and who face censorship or deplatforming risks — musicians, visual artists, writers, filmmakers creating dissident, political, or culturally provocative work.
- **Geographically excluded:** Artists in the Global South or in countries with restrictive financial systems who cannot easily receive international funding through traditional banking channels.
- **Bitcoin-curious but under-resourced:** Artists who see philosophical alignment with Bitcoin's values of sovereignty and permissionlessness but lack the technical knowledge or community support to adopt it.

Tangible Results to Date

BFTA was incorporated in Q4 2025 and is in its first operational year:

- **Grant program launched:** Application system built and live; grant processing begins Q3 2026 with initial awards of \$500–\$2,000 in BTC.
- **8+ featured artist stories published:** In-depth profiles of artists from the U.S., Tanzania, Australia, Japan, Belarus, and Alaska — documenting real creators building sovereign careers with Bitcoin and value-for-value tools.
- **3 video episodes produced:** Open-licensed "Share Your Bitcoin Journey" series featuring artists at the intersection of Bitcoin and creativity.
- **Sovereign Circle membership launched:** Five-tier monthly/annual giving program with 100+ community touchpoints (art drops, grant votes, milestone perks).
- **Full governance infrastructure published:** Bylaws, conflict of interest policy, endowment management framework, code of ethics, curatorial manifesto, and board minutes — all publicly available.
- **5-member founding board established:** Including leadership with backgrounds in arts administration, finance, technology, and community building.

- **Open-source technology platform:** Custom-built grant application system, BTCPay Server integration, and Nostr-compatible artist hub — all open source.

Measuring Outcomes

We plan to measure organizational success through:

- **Grants awarded:** Number and dollar value of grants disbursed per quarter; geographic and discipline diversity of recipients.
 - **Artist financial outcomes:** Self-reported income changes, BTC held vs. converted, and adoption of self-custody practices (6- and 12-month follow-up surveys).
 - **Workshop completion:** Number of artists completing Bitcoin literacy workshops; post-workshop adoption rates for self-custody and value-for-value tools.
 - **Platform independence:** Number of artists onboarded to Nostr, Wavlake, or other censorship-resistant platforms as a result of BFTA programs.
 - **Reserve growth:** HODL Vault balance and purchasing power trajectory toward the 1 BTC by 2030 target.
 - **Community engagement:** Sovereign Circle membership growth, donor retention, and newsletter subscriber growth.
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Scale

Scaling Plan

BFTA's scaling strategy follows three phases:

Phase 1 — Foundation (2025–2026): Build core infrastructure, launch grant program, publish artist stories, establish governance. Current phase.

Phase 2 — Growth (2027–2028): - Scale grant awards from \$500 to \$10,000 per project as reserves grow. - Launch the Sovereign Artist Residency pilot (budget: ~\$20,000–\$50,000/year). - Launch the Bitcoin Education Initiative for artists (~\$15,000–\$30,000/year). - Expand the board to 7–9 members with domain expertise in arts, Bitcoin, legal, and finance. - Establish partnerships with Bitcoin conferences, arts institutions, and education platforms.

Phase 3 — Sustainability (2029–2030+): - Scale grant range to \$500–\$25,000 per project. - Achieve 1 BTC HODL Vault target, creating a self-sustaining endowment that grows with Bitcoin's purchasing power. - Replicate the BFTA model in other communities (open-source

playbook for Bitcoin-native arts patronage). - Build a network of 50+ funded artists serving as ambassadors and workshop facilitators.

Financial Sustainability

BFTA's long-term financial model combines:

1. **Individual donations (BTC and fiat):** Through BTCPay Server and Stripe, with the Sovereign Circle membership program providing recurring monthly/annual revenue across five tiers (\$5–\$101/month).
2. **Institutional grants:** Applications to foundations aligned with arts, technology, financial inclusion, and social innovation (including this DRK application).
3. **HODL Vault appreciation:** The 5% reserve allocation creates a Bitcoin-denominated endowment. Unlike fiat endowments that lose purchasing power to inflation, a Bitcoin reserve has historically appreciated — meaning BFTA's endowment can grow even without additional contributions. This is the structural innovation that makes BFTA potentially self-sustaining at scale.
4. **Community and earned revenue:** Workshop fees (sliding scale), partnership revenue from Bitcoin conferences and arts festivals, and value-for-value contributions from content (stories, education materials published under open license).

Leader

Dion Wilson — Founder & Executive Director, Interim Board Chair

Dion Wilson is a New York City-based performing artist, educator, and arts administrator who founded Bitcoin For The Arts in 2025 after witnessing firsthand how fiat inflation and institutional gatekeeping systematically undermine independent creators. With a career spanning professional dance, Broadway, and arts education — including mentoring over 10,000 students — Wilson brings deep domain expertise in the challenges working artists face and the infrastructure they need to thrive.

Wilson's Bitcoin journey began when he recognized that the same forces eroding artists' purchasing power (monetary inflation, centralized control, platform dependence) were the exact problems Bitcoin was designed to solve. He founded BFTA to build the bridge between the arts community and the Bitcoin ecosystem — creating the first nonprofit dedicated to paying artists exclusively in Bitcoin.

A full resume/CV for Dion Wilson is attached separately per DRK requirements.

Board of Directors

Name	Role
Dion Wilson	Founder & Executive Director, Interim Board Chair
Avi Burra	Treasurer
Cheryl McGinnis	Secretary
Ahmed Klink	Board Member
Kyle Shirkness	Board Member

Why DRK + BFTA

DRK's model — unrestricted three-year funding, hands-on board service, and capacity building — is precisely what BFTA needs at this inflection point. We have built the infrastructure (technology platform, governance framework, grant program, community), and we are entering our first grant cycle. DRK's support would provide:

- **Unrestricted capital** to fund our first 50+ artist grants and launch the residency and education pilots.
- **Board expertise** to strengthen our governance, fundraising capacity, and scaling strategy as we grow from founding phase to operational scale.
- **Network access** to DRK's portfolio of 280+ social enterprises and the broader venture philanthropy community.

BFTA represents a new category of social enterprise: Bitcoin-native arts patronage. We believe this model — combining appreciating-currency grants, radical transparency, censorship-resistant infrastructure, and artist financial literacy — can fundamentally change how independent artists are funded and supported. We are looking for a partner who shares that ambition.

Bitcoin For The Arts, Inc. is a 501(c)(3) tax-exempt nonprofit. 27 W 60th St. P.O. Box 20069, New York, NY 10023 bitcoinforthearts.org